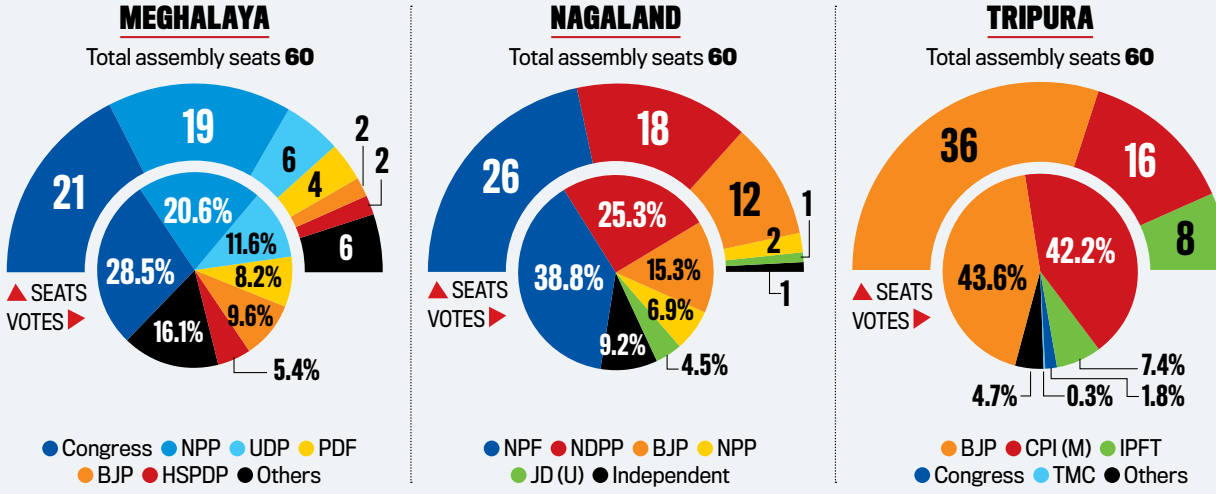
A REWIND TO 2018

In Tripura, the BJP was the outright winner after trouncing the CPI(M). In Nagaland and Meghalaya, it allied with local parties to be in government. The ultimate loser: the Congress



MEGHALAYA

In 2018, the Mukul Sangma-led Congress, which had been in power for two terms, emerged as the single largest party, winning 21 seats, while Conrad Sangma's National People's Party (NPP) won 19 seats. Eventually, the NPP, along with the BJP, the United Democratic Party (UDP), the People's Democratic Front (PDF) and the Hill State People's Democratic Party (HSPDP) and a few independent MLAs stitched up a rainbow coalition and formed the government. With two MLAs, the BJP had registered its first-ever victory in Meghalaya, where the population is 75 per cent Christian.

As Meghalaya heads to polls on February 27, the NPP has parted ways with the BJP and Mukul Sangma is now the face of the TMC. The state is set for a four-cornered fight, with the NPP, BJP, Congress and the TMC contesting independently. Even regional parties that are part of the NPP-led government are going it alone. The primary electoral issues for the Opposition are allegations against the government of corruption and mismanagement of law and order. In a state where elections are won or lost on the candidate's personal popularity, political observers say hyper-local issues, mostly related to the tribal communities, will be crucial.

BJP-NPP ties, which had already soured, reached breaking point in July 2022, with Meghalaya police arresting BJP's state vice president, Bernard R. Marak, on the charge of running a brothel in Tura, the home town of CM Sangma. There are other factors behind the separation. While the NPP aspires to be a pan-Northeast party, the BJP's expansion plans, particularly in the Garo Hills, have worried Conrad Sangma. Besides, observers say that the NPP's association with the Hindutva-inclined BJP in a Christian-dominated state have been counter-productive. The NPP has opposed the BJP on contentious issues such as the Citizenship (Amendment) Act 2019, AFSPA and anti-conversion laws.

THE TMC, THE MAIN OPPOSITION PARTY IN MEGHALAYA, IS BANKING ON MUKUL SANGMA AND I-PAC FOR ITS FIRST WIN IN THE NORTHEAST

The BJP claims that it will improve its tally from two in 2018 to at least 10-15 this time. The defection of four MLAs—two from NPP, one from TMC and one independent—to its ranks in December 2022 has bolstered its confidence. The state BJP unit has also not hesitated to deviate from its national stand on certain issues. For instance, Sanbor Shullai, one of the two BJP MLAs, publicly encouraged people to eat more beef.

The fate of the Congress has been pitiable. Since 2018, it first lost four MLAs—one resigned and three died. In November 2021, Mukul Sangma and 11 others joined the TMC and soon, five MLAs announced their support to the NPP-led government, earning suspension from the party high command. Two of them joined the BJP in December 2022. The TMC, which became the main opposition party overnight, is now banking on Mukul Sangma's influence and electoral management by Prashant Kishor's I-PAC to earn its first ever victory in a northeastern state. However, of the 12 Congress MLAs who had joined it, two have further defected to the NPP and one to the BJP. Furthermore, Mukul's area of influence is also Garo Hills,